“I haven’t drunk jasmine tea for a long time.”

My father was smiling on the screen. I was in California, staring at the perfume test strips beside him that I had sent across the Pacific. Jasmine, old book pages, leather warmed by the sun, wood after the rain. I had prepared the perfume based on my memory about my father, but I didn’t expect his preference to have changed.

I have had an exceptionally sensitive sense of smell since I was born. My family jokingly calls me a “dog nose.” At six, I often smelled my father even before I saw him. In Guangzhou, at a certain point in the evening, the hallway would fill with the mixed scents of jasmine tea, car leather, and damp air. I called it “the smell of Dad coming home.” Whenever I smelled it, I knew it was Dad.

During the pandemic, I migrated to the US to live with my mother, while my father stayed in China. Sometimes during video calls, I could even clearly see my dad’s new gray hairs, but I could no longer smell his scent. I could see my father sitting in his study through the screen, but in everyday life, whenever I heard a key turning in the lock, I knew it couldn’t be my dad.

So I decided to recreate “the smell of Dad coming home.” I experimented many times, numbering and recording each different ratio and ingredient. I increased the jasmine note, reduced the woody scent, and tried to add a little leather warmed by the sun. After the final version was sent to China, I asked my father to smell it. I thought despite all that time not living together, the perfume would be a strong enough proof that I still remembered everything about him.

My father smiled a few seconds after smelling it. He told me he hadn't had jasmine tea for a long time.

“Why not anymore?” I asked, feeling a bit frustrated. I had spent so long remembering him. How could he just change like that without noticing me? The idea was a bit childish, and honest enough to embarrass me.

“Last year, I was diagnosed with gastroesophageal reflux, and the doctor advised me to drink less tea,” he continued.

I immediately regretted my tone. I felt guilty that I hadn’t even known about any change in his health. He had stopped drinking tea, and he must have changed many other habits that I knew nothing about. What I truly missed, beyond those familiar scents, was the many small little details in his daily life that were never presented in our video calls. Perhaps in my father’s eyes, I was still the same person I was when I left Guangzhou. We loved each other, yet we each carried an outdated version of the other’s daily life.

Since then, I have watched our video calls more closely. After three yawns, I asked how he spent sleepless nights. He told me he would take a walk downstairs.

He asked me if I could add the scent of the banyan tree downstairs after rain. Holding his phone, he showed me his route from his room to the tree. As I adjusted the formula, I imagined walking beside him under the banyan tree which gave us peace.

The old jasmine tea formula is still in the drawer. It records how I, at the age of six, waited for my father to turn the key in the lock. The new bottle next to it records just one night. My father slowly told me about his current life, and I gave him my current self in return. For the first time the distance between us did not seem like a barrier to overcome for me, but more like a space where we could take time to get to know each other again.